

What They Did.

How the British state is quietly joining up its citizens' records — and turning the same tools on its own people — without the consent, the published safeguards, or the straight answers it owes Parliament.

Two systems. One playbook: **join the data, withhold the paperwork, stonewall the questions.** Every claim below is sourced to the government's own records or a court of law. Nothing here is inferred where the record is silent — the silences are marked as silences.

01 The charge, in one breath

Strip away the acronyms and there are two stories running in parallel — kept legally and factually separate throughout this document — that tell the same story about how power treats data.

TRACK A — MINISTRY OF JUSTICE

Splink: joining up the citizenry

The MoJ built and runs **Splink**, an open-source engine that probabilistically links one person's records across separate government databases. It is used operationally — courts, sentencing, a daily police feed — yet **no Data Protection Impact Assessment text, no named lawful-basis condition, and no individual opt-out has ever been published**. The ICO has never acted.

TRACK B — METROPOLITAN POLICE

Palantir: turning it on their own

The Met ran a **Palantir "Unified Data Platform" trial** profiling its **own officers** — sickness, absence, overtime, the geolocation of their work phones — on a contract **reported at ~£489,999** — fractionally below the £500,000 scrutiny threshold. When an MP asked Parliament what data went in and whether it was lawfully assessed, the Government refused to say.

Neither story is a hack, a leak, or a conspiracy theory. **Both are documented in the state's own publications**. The scandal is not that the records were stolen — it is that the joining-up was deliberate, the safeguards were never shown, and Parliament was met with a formula instead of an answer.

02 What they refused to tell Parliament

Iqbal Mohamed MP tabled four precise, answerable Written Questions about the Met's Palantir trial. Three of the four drew an identical sentence.

"Police Forces are operationally independent, and the Home Office does not review their Data Protection Impact Assessments and does not hold this information."

— Home Office (Sarah Jones MP), 11 June 2026, in answer to UIN 7092 (**what data was ingested**), UIN 7093 (**was the DPIA re-approved by the DPO**) and, in near-identical form, UIN 7202 (**was an ethical review completed**). The same boilerplate, three times, is not an accident — it is a refusal pattern.

UIN 7092 — what personal & special-category data did Palantir ingest?

"...does not hold this information." **STONEWALLED**

UIN 7093 — has the DPIA been reviewed & re-approved by the Data Protection Officer?

Neither confirmed nor denied. **STONEWALLED**

UIN 7202 — has an ethical review of the trial been completed?

"...does not monitor whether ethical reviews have been conducted." **STONEWALLED**

UIN 7091 — must local supplier risk assessments be published?

Answered — and the answer is: **"There is no separate requirement to routinely publish" them.** **ANSWERED**

Source: UK Parliament Written Questions API — questions-statements-api.parliament.uk · tabled 4–5 June 2026, answered 11 & 19 June 2026.

"We don't hold it" is not the same as "it can't be known." The rest of this document answers the questions the Government would not — from the public record.

03 What the record shows anyway — the Met / Palantir trial

They watched their own officers.

- **CONFIRMED** The "Unified Data Platform Phase 1" trial is an internal anti-corruption / integrity-screening pilot run on the Met's **own employees'** data — consolidated in Palantir Foundry since 2024.
- **CONFIRMED** Categories analysed include **illness and absence levels, overtime patterns, shift rosters, declared secondary employment**, and data from **work mobile phones and laptops including device geolocation** — the basis of officers' objections to "continuous 24/7 geolocation tracking." Sickness data is special-category-relevant.
- **CONFIRMED** The Met Police Federation called it "outrageous."

They priced it under the radar.

- **REPORTED** Reported on Contracts Finder at **~£489,999** (1 Feb – 30 Apr 2026, extended to 15 May 2026) — **just below the £500,000 MOPAC-scrutiny threshold**, and directly awarded with no open competition. The figure is to be confirmed against the primary Contracts Finder / MOPAC record and put to the Met as a question, not asserted; the £500,000 threshold (MOPAC para 4.8) and the Procurement Act anti-subdivision rule are what make the question legitimate.
- **REPORTED** The Met withheld the cost and scope of the extension as "commercially sensitive."

They never showed the homework.

- **CONFIRMED** **No DPIA for the trial has been published.** The Met's 24 April 2026 press release announcing it does not mention one.
- **UNANSWERED** Whether the DPO ever reviewed or re-approved a trial-specific DPIA — unconfirmed by anyone, including the Government.
- **UNANSWERED** **No completed ethical review** of this trial — from the Met, MOPAC, or the London Policing Ethics Panel — can be found in the public record.

The discipline that makes this stick: the headline crime-intelligence datasets people fear (CRIS/ CRIMINT, custody, ANPR, the gangs matrix, facial images) belong to a **separate** ~£50m "Unified Operational Analytics" contract — which Sadiq Khan / the Deputy Mayor **blocked on 21 May 2026** over procurement failings, with Palantir reportedly moving to sue. That deal is **not** the officer-surveillance trial, and this document never conflates the two. The provable scandal is the one that actually shipped.

04 What the record shows anyway — MoJ Splink

A separate department, a separate tool, the same pattern: lawful on paper, invisible in practice.

- **CONFIRMED** Splink is the MoJ's own probabilistic record-linkage engine (Fellegi–Sunter), built for the "Data First" programme to match a person across justice, health, education and other datasets.
- **CONFIRMED** Per the MoJ's own Algorithmic Transparency Records, the **Data First research datasets are "not for operational decision-making"** — but the **same Splink tooling runs operationally**: courts and sentencing, batch and real-time matching, a Core Person Record pilot, and a **daily North Essex feed into police systems**.
- **THE GAP** The lawful basis cited publicly is the **Digital Economy Act 2017 (Part 5)** plus common-law administration-of-justice powers. But there is **no published DPIA text, no named UK GDPR Article 6/9 condition, no DPA 2018 Schedule 1 paragraph, no Equality/Human-Rights (Art 8) assessment, and no individual privacy notice or opt-out**.
- **THE GAP** The ICO has **never taken any enforcement action** on Splink or Data First.

One honesty marker that makes the whole dossier credible: **Palantir does not run Splink**. There is no documented technical link between them anywhere — we looked, hard, and say so plainly. They are two arms of the same instinct in two departments: **where Splink counts the population, Palantir acts on it**.

Sources: gov.uk Algorithmic Transparency Records — [moj-data-first-splink](https://gov.uk/moj-data-first-splink) (17 Dec 2024) & [moj-splink-master-record](https://gov.uk/moj-splink-master-record) (6 Oct 2025) · [MoJ Data First privacy statement](https://gov.uk/moj-data-first-privacy-statement) · github.com/moj-analytical-services/splink.

05 Why "lawful basis on paper" is not the end of it

Here is the line we hold with discipline — because overclaiming would hand them the win.

No court and no regulator has yet ruled against Splink, Data First, the ONS Integrated Data Service, or ADR UK. We say that plainly. Anyone who tells you the courts have condemned these systems is wrong, and we will not pretend otherwise.

But the legal shortcut they all lean on — **putting the safeguards in policy and guidance rather than on the face of the law** — has already been struck down, three times, **right next door**:

RULED UNLAWFUL [2021] EWCA Civ 800	Court of Appeal, 26 May 2021 (Warby LJ): the Home Office immigration exemption was unlawful — an "unauthorised derogation from the GDPR," failing Article 23(2).
RULED UNLAWFUL [2023] EWHC 713 (Admin)	High Court, 29 Mar 2023 (Saini J): the <i>revised</i> exemption was still unlawful — safeguards "must appear on the face of the legislation... with statutory force," not in policy.

RULED UNLAWFUL [2023] EWCA
Civ 1474

Court of Appeal, 11 Dec 2023: confirmed the breach of Article 23(2). Only then did the Government legislate the fix (SI 2024/342, in force 8 March 2024).

The principle the courts laid down is general: **when the state processes people's data in ways that touch their rights, the protections have to be in law — binding, published, enforceable — not in an internal document the public never sees.** That is exactly the standard Splink and the Met trial have not been shown to meet. The closest regulator finding on joining-up itself — the ICO's March 2021 warning that the Cabinet Office had run the National Fraud Initiative expansion **without a DPIA** — points the same way.

06 What to ask now — and who has to answer

Every gap above maps to a question someone is legally obliged to answer. These are ready to table.

To the MoJ (WPQ): Will the Department publish the full DPIA, the named UK GDPR Article 6 and Article 9 conditions, and the DPA 2018 Schedule 1 paragraph relied on for operational Splink matching — including the daily North Essex police feed?

To the MoJ (WPQ): What individual notification or opt-out exists for people whose records are linked by Splink for operational, as opposed to research, purposes?

To the Met (FOI): The trial-specific DPIA, the ROPA, the ingestion schema, and the named DPO sign-off for the Unified Data Platform Phase 1 trial — plus the cost and scope of the extension to 15 May 2026.

To the London Policing Ethics Panel / MOPAC: Was any ethical review of the UDP trial commissioned or completed, and will it be published?

To the ICO: Has the Commissioner opened any engagement on either the Met trial or operational Splink — and if not, why not?

A full pack of **16 draft Written Questions to the MoJ (+2 to the Home Office)**, matched FOI request texts, and a sourced evidence annex accompanies this summary. Every factual claim in this document is drawn from the government's own publications, the UK Parliament Written Questions API, or named and dated court judgments. Where the record is silent, this document says so rather than guessing.

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